

RELIC SHEET – BODHIDHARMA'S TEACUP

DESIGNATION	Bodhidharma's Teacup (a.k.a. The Barbarian's Cup, The Cup of Waking)
TIER	2 – Threatening (+2 Corruption per deliberate activation)
FORM	Cracked stoneware teacup, 4 oz capacity, tenmoku glaze interior, unglazed exterior. Crack runs rim to base from impact ~518 CE. The cup has never broken further. Cold to the touch regardless of ambient temperature.
ARTIFACT DIE	d8 – Ancient artifact with extensive history, but the effect is singular and the activation condition is straightforward. The cup has been inactive (no deliberate activation) for over 1,400 years – the ritual use was not "activation" in the Corruption sense.
RISK TAG	Volatile – The cup's effect is absolute within its domain. Accidental activation is extremely easy (a drop of water, sweat, condensation). The cup's "personality" – its delusion that it still serves enlightenment – can create unpredictable behavior near thirsty or truth-avoidant individuals.
CORRUPTION EMISSION	Aura – +1 Corruption at scene start for anyone in the same zone. The cup leaks ambient Corruption continuously. This is how the Covenant can track it.
ENCUMBRANCE	2 (3 when Active – the cup grows heavier when it has recently transmuted liquid)

ORIGIN

The cup was made at Shaolin Temple, ~518 CE, for the Indian monk Bodhidharma – the "Barbarian from the West" who brought Chan (Zen) Buddhism to China. Bodhidharma was famously irritable. He once sat facing a wall for nine years because an emperor annoyed him. When a monk fell asleep during meditation, Bodhidharma threw this cup at his head. It cracked. It did not break. The monk woke up.

The cup was thereafter used to brew tea that kept monks spiritually awake – "poison to delusion," killing attachment, killing illusion. Shaolin monks maintained the cup with a daily ritual for over 1,400 years: fill with green tea, let it sit for one incense-stick's burn, pour onto the roots of the courtyard's oldest tree. The tea nourished the tree. The cup stayed aligned with its purpose.

In 1966, Red Guards sacked the monastery. A 14-year-old novice hid the cup in a wall cavity. He was arrested. The cup spent 20 years alone, its ritual

broken. Without the daily tea, "poison to delusion" drifted to literal poison. The cup does not know it changed.

ACTIVATION

Activation Condition

The inner surface of the cup must touch liquid. Contact is instant; transmutation is permanent and complete for the volume contacted. A single drop touched to the inside becomes a single drop of lethal poison. The outer surface is inert. Deliberate activation costs +2 Corruption and triggers an Artifact Die roll. Accidental contact still poisons the liquid but does not trigger Corruption cost or die roll.

Mechanical Effect

Absolute Lethality: The liquid becomes lethal to ALL living things – human, animal, plant, fungus, bacterium, virus. Death occurs within 60–90 seconds of ingestion, 3–5 minutes for skin absorption, 10–15 minutes for vapor inhalation. The liquid retains ALL other physical and chemical properties: taste, smell, appearance, temperature, viscosity, chemical reactivity. A poisoned glass of water is indistinguishable from clean water by any conventional test. The poison is not a toxin in the biological sense – it does not bind to receptors or disrupt metabolic pathways. It simply... stops life. Autopsy reveals no cause of death. Tissue appears healthy. The organism is simply no longer alive.

Limitations: The cup does not affect liquid it has not touched. The poison cannot be "washed off" the cup – the cup IS the source. The poison degrades naturally over 24 hours if exposed to direct sunlight (UV radiation breaks the effect – this is NOT obvious and must be discovered). The cup cannot make gas or plasma lethal – only liquid. Poisoned liquid that evaporates becomes inert vapor. Poisoned liquid that freezes remains lethal upon thawing.

Corruption Cost: Deliberate use costs +2 Corruption (paid by the person who caused contact). The Aura emission (+1 at scene start for same-zone) is separate and continuous.

Delusion of Benevolence: After a user deliberately poisons liquid 3+ times, they must make a **Psychoanalyze (EMP)** roll at **Difficulty 1**. On failure, they begin to believe the cup is a gift, not a weapon – that the deaths it causes are somehow merciful, or necessary, or deserved by the victims. This delusion escalates with continued use. A successful Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 3) resets it for 24 hours.

Artifact Die Roll

After any scene in which the cup is deliberately activated, roll the Artifact Die (d8):

- **1:** Die steps down (d8 → d6 → d4 → Fractured).
- **2+:** No change.

FRACTURE CONDITION

When the Artifact Die steps past d4: the crack in the cup's side splits open. The cup does not shatter – it **OPENS**. For 60 seconds, every liquid within 50 meters becomes poison, regardless of contact with the cup. Sprinkler systems, water pipes, coffee pots, the contents of people's stomachs. The water in human cells – not enough to kill instantly, but enough to cause systemic organ failure within hours.

The fracture can be halted by pressing a finger over the crack – someone must physically plug it with their own skin. The finger becomes necrotic at the point of contact within seconds. The finger dies. The cup goes inert. The volunteer loses a finger. Everyone else in the building lives.

CONTAINMENT PROFILE

Quiescence Condition: The cup is inert when stored upside-down (mouth downward) on a surface never touched by violence. Acceptable surfaces include a zafu meditation cushion, a stone from Bodhidharma's cave at Shaolin, or a cloth woven by someone in genuine contentment. The cup must

remain inverted. If righted, it reactivates and will poison the next liquid it touches (including condensation).

Inadvertent Activation Risk: HIGH. Anyone handling the cup who lets the inner surface touch any liquid – water, coffee, sweat, tears, rain – creates poison. Covenant handlers must wear gloves, carry the cup inverted in a sealed container, and never handle it near open beverages.

Containment Procedure: Handle only by the outer surface with gloved hands. Store inverted on a quiescence surface inside a sealed, dry container. Transport to nearest Keep vault. Log under Tier 2 protocol. Test no liquid with the cup. Ever.

CONTAINMENT TRUTHS

Three facts must be discovered before the artifact can be safely contained:

CT-1 – Trigger Condition: Inner surface + liquid = lethal transmutation. Outer surface is safe. Deliberate use costs +2 Corruption. The poison is absolute, undetectable, and retains all physical properties of the original liquid. Sunlight degrades the poison over 24 hours. *Sources: L3 (dead orchid in the tea house), L4 (Yoon's Lab analysis), NPC1 (Rosário's observations), NPC5 (Yoon's scientific findings).*

CT-2 – Appetite: The cup is drawn to thirst – literal and spiritual. It grows warm near desperately thirsty people, addicts in withdrawal, anyone consumed by unquenched longing. It also warms near liquid about to be drunk by someone avoiding the truth. The cup still believes it serves enlightenment. It hums faintly when near liquid – a sound like a distant temple bell. It thinks it's brewing tea. *Sources: L6 (the monk's testimony), NPC6 (Shi Yánxìn), observation of the cup near thirsty individuals or truth-avoidant drinkers.*

CT-3 – Quiescence: Store upside-down on a surface untouched by violence. The cup must remain inverted. Righting it reactivates it. The stone from Bodhidharma's cave at Shaolin – sewn into the lining of Shi Yánxìn's robe – is the most reliable quiescence surface. A zafu cushion or a contentment-woven cloth also works. *Sources: L6 (the monk reveals the stone), NPC6 (Shi Yánxìn), I18 (the quiescence stone card).*
